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CP(M) STATE SECRETARY PINARAYI VIJAYAN (LEFT) AND CHIEF MINISTER ACHUTHANANDAN NOW FACE DALIT WRATH

within three months. It was the first major agitation in Kerala led not by a political party but the landless themselves of whom the majority belonged to the Scheduled Castes who form 12 per cent of the state population. The unprecedented struggle was also unique as it was the first agitation by the landless Dalits targeted not just against the Left Democratic Front (LDF) Government, but the mainstream communist parties in general which traditionally claimed a monopoly over their cause.

"Chengara struggle and its culmination showed for the first time that Dalits no longer were under the feudal yoke of the communist parties which have always used them to do their menial jobs," says Laha Gopalan, former CPI(M) member and the supremo of the Sadhujana Vimochana Munnani that led the Chengara agitation. Chengara was only the culmination of a process which saw the gradual distancing of large sections of Dalits and tribals from their traditional political parties, the Left, which are largely credited to have given them courage in the past to stand up for

their rights. The Ambedkarite Dalit identity movement which began to take shape by the 1970s in many parts of the country had held all mainstream political parties responsible for the community's continuing backwardness. In Kerala, the movement was weaker than elsewhere, thanks to the domination of the mainstream Left among the community. But the situation began to change by the '90s with the decay of the Left parties and simultaneous growth of new forms of identity and micro-politics led by former Naxalite and Dalit intellectuals focusing on issues like caste, gender, environment, etc. It was Ayyankali, a 19th century Dalit social reformer, who inspired Kerala Dalits, much like B.R. Ambedkar had done elsewhere in the country. The Dalits' biggest grouse against the Left was about its proudest achievement, the land reforms initiated by the first communist government of 1957.

"The much-trumpeted land reforms have worked only to our disadvantage. Instead of distributing land to its actual tillers like us, the reforms helped the tenants who

Dalit leaders say though the Left's Brahmin leadership has given way to other castes now, there is still no Dalit representation.